‘Gunjan, you run and get the clearances and draw weapons; we’ll prepare the helicopter,’ the flight commander ordered after he had finished the briefing. Since it was a non-flying day, we had not even drawn our rifles and pistols from the armoury. I sprinted to the Gypsy and went straight to the office to get clearances. I dashed to the armoury after that and got our weapons. When I reached the helicopter after getting the required documents and weapons, the flight commander was already there talking on a landline.

‘The sanitization report has not reached yet,’ the flight commander said after hanging up. There was a sense of urgency in his voice. ‘It doesn’t matter; you go ahead with the start-up. And I want a fast start-up.’

Everything was in fast-forward mode that evening. I followed the fast start-up procedure, in which a pilot is required to perform all necessary checks but needs to expedite them considerably to save time. I could see from the cockpit that a jittery flight commander was pacing up and down near the telephone. I contacted the air traffic control (ATC) on radio to ask for permission to start up, which was denied since a sanitization report was pending. In Kargil, if a pilot had to go for a sortie at that time, the army had to sanitize that particular area, and a sanitization report had to be obtained before a sortie could be flown in that area. This was to ensure there was no grave threat to the aircraft.

I went ahead with the start-up anyway and convinced the ATC that I would not engage the rotors until the sanitization report reached us. Seeing that I was adamant and would not back down, the ATC did not say anything. The flight commander got into the helicopter and strapped himself to the seat. Even in this cold weather both of us were sweating. Our overalls were drenched.

‘The sanitization report is still pending,’ he said. ‘What do we do now?’

Every second of delay put our mission in graver danger of jeopardy. The failure of this mission could result in casualties the next day. Lack of damage assessment could compromise plans. I did not want any of it to happen. Nobody should have to die because a sortie had failed due to a delayed sanitization report, I thought.